1962 conflict with China, and several more wars fought with Pakistan since the first armed confrontation in 1947.

The Indian Army has, by and large, remained a professional force that has stayed clear of involvement in politics. Its main objective has always been to defend the country's frontiers and to safeguard what the elected government considers India's national security interests to be. Even retired army officers prefer to become security analysts for think-tanks rather than seeking careers as politicians.

On the other hand, the role-model for the PLA, after the war, was personified in the fictitious soldier Lei Feng,[10] a humble, apple-cheeked character who would repair his army truck with a wrench in one hand and a book by Chairman Mao in the other—and whose goal, allegedly in his own words, was to 'become a stainless-steel screw for the Party'.[11] The legend—and myth—of Lei Feng may seem comical in today's world, but it has survived decades of political change in China. Even today, 5 March is officially celebrated as Learn from Lei Feng Day.

With or without Lei Feng, the PLA, as the name suggests, had always been an ideologically motivated 'people's army' set up in the late 1920s at the end of the first alliance between the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) and the nationalist Kuomintang (KMT). Led by Zhou Enlai, He Long, and Zhu De, some of the KMT troops had rebelled against the government during an uprising at Nanchang. The uprising was crushed, but a Communist armed force, first called the Chinese Workers' and Peasants' Red Army, was officially formed on 1 August 1927. It became known simply as the Red Army and fought several battles against the KMT's troops. It was further hardened during an epic military retreat from its old stronghold in Jiangxi in the south to Yan'an in Shaanxi in northern China in 1934–5. The Long March, as it came to be known, lasted for 370 days during which the Communist forces covered 9,000 kilometres. Only 8,000 made it to Yan'an, and of these, 7,000 were from the original 86,000 who had set out from the south in October 1934. Disease, hunger, and battles with government forces as well as armies led by local warlords had taken a heavy toll.

At the new, well-defended base area in Yan'an, the Red Army was rebuilt into a formidable fighting force. During the war against Japanese invaders, which lasted from 1937 to 1945, the Red Army was allied with